Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Round Rock Public Library
City of Round Rock
Round Rock, TX 78664

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position in Youth Services at the Round Rock Public Library. I live in Austin, so this is a library I could serve without relocating, and most of what the job involves day to day is work I already do: taking materials in, shelving them, keeping a collection orderly, building displays and printed material that get people through the door, and helping somebody find what they are looking for.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, where I manage the archive of every printed piece we produce. One campaign might be a letter going out to the whole donor file, the next a proposal prepared for a single major donor, the next the invitation set for a conference. I take the samples in from the printer, sort and label them, shelve them by campaign and mail code, keep the shelves accurate, and pull what a writer or a director needs. Designing printed material that makes somebody want to show up is the other half of the job, and it is the part that transfers most directly to youth programming.

When I inherited that collection I designed a SQL database for it, set a consistent record for each piece, cataloged several campaign years against that standard, and built a searchable reading room over the top, so the whole department can find a past piece on its own. I built two public websites the same way: the Free Knowledge Library, a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database and the classification scheme and built the catalog readers search; and StateTrack, which publishes state campaign finance records for all fifty states. When a patron cannot find something in a catalog, I understand why from the inside.

I want to be straightforward about the gap. I have more than four years of public-facing service, but I have not worked professionally with children and teens. What I can offer in the meantime is the rest of the role done well, the displays and bibliographies, the promotional material, the catalog and reference help, while I learn the age-group work from the people who already do it.

The closest I have come is at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. I worked with a donor on a gift of a complete *Harvard Classics* set, carried it from the first conversation through to the books being on the shelf, gave them a tour of the library in person, and kept them updated on where the set had been placed. I was also the on-site contact for visitor tours generally, guiding groups of all ages and answering their questions about the collections. That is what convinced me to pursue this work properly.

Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to, explaining procedures that were not obvious and processing more than five hundred transcripts and exam records accurately.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I noticed Round Rock offers tuition assistance, which is a genuine part of the appeal. Thank you for your time, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie